# Active-layer thickness prediction and regional differences across permafrost regions using a physics-residual machine-learning workflow

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**Abstract**

Active-layer thickness (ALT) is measured at few clustered sites, and models extending them face a trade-off: a Stefan model transfers to unobserved regions but uses one soil coefficient, whereas machine learning (ML) fits its training sites and fails beyond them, as do gridded products. We compared a physics-residual workflow, in which gradient boosting learns the residual of a recalibrated Stefan model from climate, terrain and soil inputs, with the Stefan model, direct ML and five products on 19,172 site-year observations from Alaska, the Lena Delta and Canada. Under spatial-block validation it reduced the Stefan error by 3.6 cm in the Lena Delta and 3.7 cm in Canada, a gain requiring soil and terrain inputs. With a region withheld, direct ML exceeded the Stefan error by 17.8 cm in the Lena Delta, whereas the physics-residual model stayed within 2.0 cm and gained 3.9 cm from 25 local labels. On the same site-years ML products missed the thin Lena Delta active layers, where the physics-residual model was most accurate. Anchoring the learner to the physics gives accuracy where labels are dense and transferability where they are scarce; the year-labelled 1 km maps for 2011–2024 include an area of applicability and prediction intervals.

**Keywords:** permafrost, active-layer thickness, Stefan model, physics-guided machine learning, spatial cross-validation, ERA5-Land

# Introduction

The active layer is the near-surface ground above permafrost that thaws each summer and refreezes each winter. Its thickness (ALT) sets the depth of seasonal thaw and controls ground stability, near-surface hydrology and the amount of soil organic carbon exposed to decomposition[1–3]. ALT responds to the thermal conditions of each year, and this year-to-year variation is part of the signal recorded by long-term programmes such as the Circumpolar Active Layer Monitoring (CALM) network[4,5]. The observations, however, are few and clustered: most come from a small number of campaigns and long-term grids, many sites are visited once, and large parts of the permafrost region have none[6,7]. Any ALT map therefore rests on a model that extends sparse observations to unobserved cells and years, and the question is which kind of model does so reliably.

Two routes exist. The Stefan solution relates the thaw depth to the thawing degree-days (TDD) of the season through one coefficient that summarises the thermal properties and moisture of the soil[4,8,9]. It responds to the climate of each year and, having one parameter, can be refitted with few observations and applied far from them; its weakness is that one coefficient per region cannot represent the soils and terrain within the region, which leave systematic residuals. Machine learning (ML) takes the opposite position: it fits the training sites closely from climate, terrain and soil predictors, but it must learn the climate response from the labels, and its accuracy falls at locations unlike the training sites when it is validated with spatially separated data[10–13]. The gridded ALT products that now cover the northern permafrost region sit on these two routes. The process-based ESA CCI product solves the ground heat equation forced by satellite land-surface temperature[14,15]; the ML products of Liu et al.[16] and Wei et al.[17] relate site-year observations to yearly predictors, and the products of Aalto et al.[18] and Ran et al.[19] map a multi-year mean. The ML products are validated by random or leave-one-site-out splits within their own site sets, with reported errors from 21.6 cm[16] to 60.5 cm[17] that are not comparable with each other, and none has been evaluated against observations of a stated year in a region that contributed no training sites.

Physics-guided learning, in which a physical model carries the dominant response and a learner corrects what the physics omits, has improved accuracy and extrapolation in lake, river and soil applications[20–22], and in Alaska the Stefan model retained its accuracy on held-out sites better than a random forest did[23]. Whether a learner that corrects the Stefan model keeps the transferability of the physics while gaining the accuracy of ML has not been tested for ALT, and three questions decide its practical value: under which conditions the correction improves on the physics, how many local observations a new region needs, and how such a model compares with the published products when all are scored on the same sites and years.

Here we answer these questions with a site-year design, in which every label, climate input, prediction and score refers to one observation site in one stated year, and the climate input is computed from ERA5-Land for that year and accumulated to the observation day[24]. With 19,172 site-year observations of 2010–2024 from Alaska, the Lena Delta and north-western Canada, we compare the Stefan model, direct ML and a physics-residual workflow, in which gradient boosting learns the residual of a

locally recalibrated Stefan model from 23 climate, terrain and soil inputs, under five validation designs that range from random splits to the hold-out of an entire region, and we score five published products on the same site-years. The study (i) shows how and why the ranking of the methods changes with the validation design, (ii) identifies the conditions and the number of local labels under which the residual learner improves on the physics, (iii) explains the regional differences between the published products, and (iv) delivers year-labelled 1 km ALT maps of the three regions for 2011–2024 with an area of applicability and prediction intervals.

# Data and methods

## Study regions and active-layer observations

We used three regions with dense, multi-year thaw-depth observations: Alaska, the Lena Delta and north-western Canada (Canada (NW) in the figures and tables; Fig. 1, Table 1). Observations for Alaska and Canada were taken from the ABoVE soil moisture and active-layer thickness compilation, version 2[6], and from the CALM end-of-season grid values[5]; observations for the Lena Delta were taken from the ALLena thaw-depth data set[7]. ABoVE probe measurements were restricted to August–October and to values between 0 and 300 cm, because measurements made earlier in the season record thaw depth rather than the seasonal maximum. ALLena measurements were restricted to August–September values without the probe-limit flag; the seasonal maximum of each location and year was taken as the label and the mean day of its measurements as the observation day. Observations were grouped by site, defined as a location with coordinates rounded to 0.0001° (about 10 m), and averaged within each site and year, retaining the mean day of observation; probe points of the ABoVE transects are therefore separate sites, and several sites can lie in one 1 km cell. CALM values without a date were assigned day 244 (1 September). We kept the years 2010–2024, for which year-specific climate inputs are available. The resulting labels comprise 15,540 site-years in Alaska (2010–2024), 2,436 in the Lena Delta (2010–2022) and 1,196 in Canada (2010–2019 and 2021–2024), distributed over 73, 16 and 26 blocks of 0.5° (Table 1). The sites lie in 321, 143 and 71 cells of 1 km, that is 910, 244 and 144 cell-years; up to 701 sites of one transect fall in one cell and year, so that site-years are not independent samples at the 1 km scale, which the spatial-block design accounts for. The three programmes differ in protocol (probe transects in ABoVE and ALLena, 1 km grid means of about 100 probe points in CALM) and in site selection; all were used as reported, and the model error by source is given in Supplementary Table S8. Throughout the study, every label, climate input, prediction and score refers to one site in one stated year: a label of year $y$ is paired only with the climate of year $y$, and a map of year $y$ uses only the climate of year $y$. Sources, versions and licences are listed in Supplementary Table S1, the years used in each analysis in Supplementary Table S2 and the processing steps in Supplementary Methods S1.

**Table 1** Data and years used. Top: ALT labels by region (site-years of 2010–2024 with year-specific climate input; a site is an observation location with coordinates rounded to 0.0001°, and the 1 km cells are the map cells that contain the sites; blocks are the 0.5° cells used for spatial cross-validation and bootstrap; there are no Canadian labels in 2020). Bottom: inputs and products, with their spatial domain, resolution, the period available and the years used in this study.

| Region | Site-years | Sites | 1 km cells | Blocks | Years | Sites ≥4 yr | Largest year |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Alaska | 15,540 | 13,253 | 321 | 73 | 2010–2024 | 203 | 2014 (51%) |
| Lena Delta | 2,436 | 2,206 | 143 | 16 | 2010–2022 | 25 | 2016 (28%) |
| Canada (NW) | 1,196 | 730 | 71 | 26 | 2010–2024 | 48 | 2022 (37%) |

| Data | Domain | Resolution | Available | Used | Role |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ERA5-Land monthly [24] | global | 0.1° (about 9 km) | 1950– | 2010–2024; mean 2011–2024 | Climate input |
| Copernicus DEM [25] | global | 30 m | static | – | Terrain |
| SoilGrids 2.0 [26] | global | 250 m | static | – | Soil |
| MODIS MOD13Q1, MOD10A2 [27,28] | global | 250 m, 500 m | 2000– | 2010–2024 | Sensitivity test |
| ESA CCI permafrost probability [14] | Northern Hemisphere | 1 km | 1997–2021 | mean 1997–2021 | Map domain (probability ≥ 50%) |
| Wei et al. [17] | Northern Hemisphere | 1 km | yearly 2000–2024 | 2010–2024 | Comparison |
| Liu et al. [16] | Northern Hemisphere | 1 km | yearly 2003–2020 | 2010–2020 | Comparison |
| ESA CCI ALT v4 [14] | Northern Hemisphere | 1 km | yearly 1997–2021 | 2010–2021 | Comparison |
| ESA CCI ALT v5 [15] | Northern Hemisphere | 1 km | yearly 1997–2023 | 2010–2023 | Comparison |
| Aalto et al. [18] | circum-Arctic | 30″ (about 1 km) | mean 2000–2014 | one value per cell | Comparison |
| Yi and Kimball [29] | Alaska (ABoVE domain) | 1 km | yearly 2001–2015 | 2010–2015 | Reference, not scored |

## Year-specific climate input

Monthly ERA5-Land fields for January 2010 to December 2024 [24] (2 m air temperature, top-layer soil temperature and snow water equivalent) were extracted at the nearest land grid cell of each site. For site $c$ and year $y$, the thawing degree-day sum is

$$\mathrm{TDD}_{c,y} = \sum_{m=1}^{12} \max(T_{c,y,m},\, 0)\, d_{y,m}, \tag{1}$$

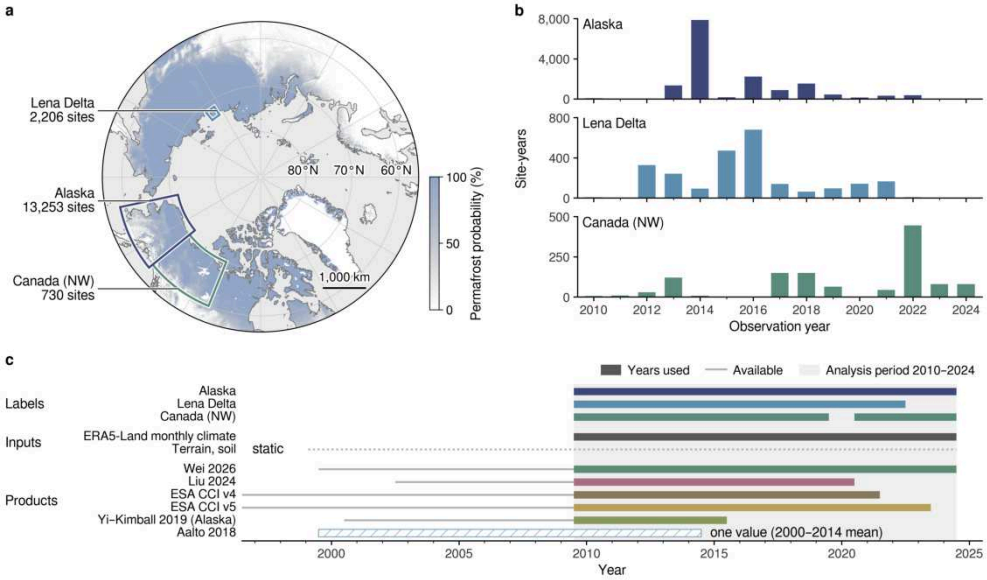



**Fig. 1 Study regions, observations and data periods. a**, ESA CCI permafrost probability (mean of 1997–2021) with the three study regions and the number of sites with ALT labels in 2010–2024. **b**, Site-year labels per observation year. **c**, Periods covered by the labels, the ERA5-Land climate input, the static covariates and the six published products; dark bars mark the years with product values at the label sites, and the shaded band marks the analysis period.

where $T_{c,y,m}$ is the monthly mean air temperature and $d_{y,m}$ the number of days in month $m$. Because most observations were made before the end of the thaw season, the model input is the TDD accumulated to the day of observation $t$,

$$\mathrm{TDD}^{\mathrm{obs}}_{c,y} = C_{c,y,k-1} + \frac{t - t_{k-1}}{d_{y,k}} \left(C_{c,y,k} - C_{c,y,k-1}\right), \tag{2}$$

where $C_{c,y,k}$ is the cumulative TDD to the end of month $k$, $k$ is the month containing $t$ and $t_{k-1}$ is the last day of the preceding month. Seven further climate variables were computed for each cell and year: the mean annual air temperature, $\sqrt{\mathrm{TDD}}$, the warmest and the coldest monthly mean temperature, the freezing degree-days of the preceding winter (October $y-1$ to April $y$), the mean top-layer soil temperature and the mean snow water equivalent of the hydrological year (October $y-1$ to September $y$) (Supplementary Table S3, Supplementary Methods S2). Two alternative inputs were evaluated on the same site-years: the full-season TDD of the observation year, and the 2011–2024 mean of the yearly values (mean climate input), which corresponds to the multi-year inputs of existing products. At the label sites the TDD accumulated to the observation day is a median of 0.73, 0.81 and 0.89 of the full-season sum in Alaska, the Lena Delta and Canada, because most observations are made in August. Yearly maps therefore use the TDD accumulated to day of year 244 (1 September in non-leap years), the end-of-season reference date of the CALM protocol, which lies within the range of the training labels (pooled interquartile range of observation days

224–234); a map value represents the thaw depth reached by 1 September of the stated year, not the full-season maximum.

## Static covariates

Six terrain variables (elevation, slope, the sine and cosine of aspect, topographic position index and roughness) were computed from the 30 m Copernicus DEM[25] in a $33 \times 33$ pixel window (about 1 km) around each site. Nine soil variables (clay, sand, silt, bulk density, coarse fragments and pH at 5–15 cm, and soil organic carbon at 0–5, 5–15 and 15–30 cm) were sampled from SoilGrids 2.0 at 250 m[26]. The main feature vector $\mathbf{x}$ therefore contains 23 variables (eight climate, six terrain and nine soil). Sensitivity tests used nested sets: climate only; climate and terrain; the main set plus MODIS summer NDVI, EVI and snow-off timing for 2010–2024 (MOD13Q1 and MOD10A2, version 6.1)[27,28]; the main set plus high-resolution soil carbon and land-cover classes[30]; and all variables including the climate of the preceding year. The ESA CCI permafrost probability (mean of 1997–2021)[14] was used only to define the map domain (probability of at least 50%) and not as a predictor.

## Model formulation

The Stefan model describes the thaw depth as

$$\widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{\mathrm{S}} = E\,\sqrt{\mathrm{TDD}^{\mathrm{obs}}}, \tag{3}$$

where $E$ ($\mathrm{cm\,(^{\circ}C\,d)^{-1/2}}$) summarises the thermal properties and moisture of the soil[8,9]. The relation holds within a season at the Lena Delta monitoring sites and, with more scatter, among years at cells observed repeatedly (Supplementary Fig. S1). We chose the Stefan model as the physical anchor because it has one parameter, which can be refitted from few observations and transferred between regions, and because its input is the year-specific TDD; the Kudryavtsev model[31] with a scaling coefficient and a non-negative combination of both models were evaluated as alternative anchors (Supplementary Table S5). Fitting the coefficient, often called the edaphic factor, to local observations follows the practice of Stefan-based ALT mapping[4,32]. For a set of $n$ training labels $y_i$ with $s_i = \sqrt{\mathrm{TDD}_i^{\mathrm{obs}}}$, the coefficient is recalibrated by least squares through the origin,

$$\hat{E} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{n} y_i\, s_i}{\sum_{i=1}^{n} s_i^2}. \tag{4}$$

The source-coefficient Stefan model uses $\hat{E}$ fitted on the other two regions, and the recalibrated Stefan model uses $\hat{E}$ fitted on the training labels of the target region. The physics-residual model retains the recalibrated Stefan prediction as an anchor and adds a learned correction (Fig. 2):

$$\widehat{\mathrm{ALT}} = \hat{E}\,s + \lambda\, g(\mathbf{x}), \qquad g = \arg\min_{f} \sum_{i=1}^{n} \Big[\Big(y_i - \hat{E}\,s_i\Big) - f(\mathbf{x}_i)\Big]^2, \tag{5}$$

where $g$ is a CatBoost gradient-boosting regressor[33] (600 iterations, learning rate 0.03, depth 6, L2 regularisation 3) and $\lambda = 0.5$ shrinks the correction towards the physical anchor. CatBoost was used as the default learner because gradient-boosted trees need no feature scaling and are the usual reference for tabular data of this size[34]; random forest, a multilayer perceptron, TabM and FT-Transformer[35–37] were run in its place as a sensitivity test, and no learner was best in all regions (Supplementary Fig. S2). The value $\lambda = 0.5$ was chosen as a compromise between the within-region gain, which increased with $\lambda$ (Lena Delta −5.1 cm at $\lambda = 1$), and the region hold-out error, which also increased with $\lambda$ (Lena Delta +5.4 cm at $\lambda = 1$); $\lambda = 0.25$ and 1 are reported as sensitivity cases. Three alternative structures place the physical information elsewhere,

$$\begin{aligned} &\widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{\mathrm{D}} = f_{\mathrm{D}}(\mathbf{x}), \qquad \widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{\mathrm{I}} = f_{\mathrm{I}}\Big(\mathbf{x},\, \hat{E}\, s,\, \widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{\mathrm{K}}\Big), \\ &\widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{\mathrm{A}} = f_{\mathrm{A}}(\mathbf{x}) \text{ fitted to } \{(\mathbf{x}_i, y_i)\}_{i=1}^{n} \cup \{(\mathbf{x}_j, \hat{E}\, s_j)\}_{j=1}^{n}, \end{aligned} \tag{6}$$

where direct ML ($f_{\mathrm{D}}$) fits CatBoost to ALT from $\mathbf{x}$ alone, physics-input ML ($f_{\mathrm{I}}$) adds the recalibrated Stefan prediction and the Kudryavtsev[31] prediction $\widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{\mathrm{K}}$ as features, and physics pseudo-labels ($f_{\mathrm{A}}$) augment the $n$ training rows with an equal number of rows $j$ drawn from the cells of the scoring fold, with their covariates and the training-fold Stefan prediction as the target. All learned models were fitted with three random seeds and their predictions averaged (the transfer models without target labels with one seed). SHAP values[38] of the residual and direct models were computed for models fitted to all labels of each region.

## Validation designs and uncertainty

All models were evaluated on out-of-fold predictions under five designs[10,11]: random five-fold cross-validation by site-year; spatial-block five-fold cross-validation, with 0.5° blocks assigned to folds balanced by the number of site-years (main design); year hold-out, in which each observation year with at least 20 site-years is predicted by models trained on the other years; block-by-year hold-out, in which both the block fold and the year of the scored site-years are excluded from training (folds with at least 10 site-years); and region hold-out, in which a region is predicted by models trained on the other two regions after removing training cells within 100 km of the test region. Accuracy is expressed as

$$\mathrm{RMSE} = \left[\frac{1}{n}\sum_{i=1}^{n}(\hat{y}_i - y_i)^2\right]^{1/2}, \qquad \Delta\mathrm{RMSE}_{A,B} = \mathrm{RMSE}_A - \mathrm{RMSE}_B, \tag{7}$$

where both terms of ΔRMSE are computed on the same site-years, so that negative values favour method $A$. Uncertainty was quantified with a paired block bootstrap[10,39]: the 0.5° blocks were resampled with replacement $B = 2000$ times (1000 times for the label-number experiments and for part of the covariate-set and learner sensitivity runs, Supplementary Table S4), ΔRMSE was recomputed from all site-years of the resampled blocks, and the 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles of the replicates

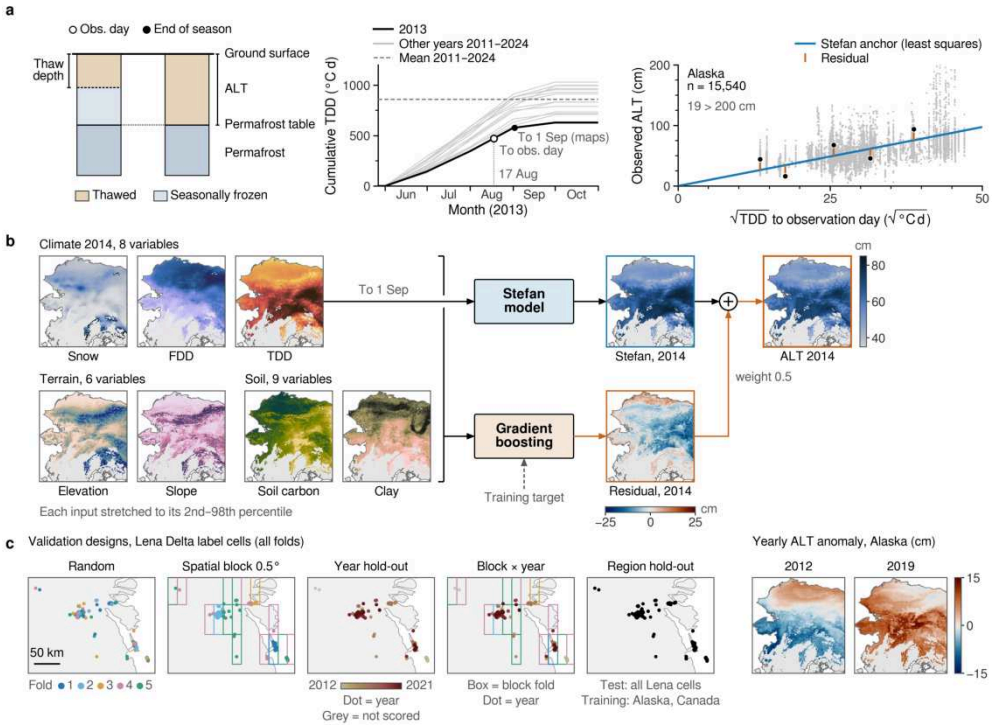



**Fig. 2 Site-year design, Stefan anchor, physics-residual model and validation designs.** **a**, Thaw depth on the observation day and ALT at the end of the season (left); cumulative thawing degree-days of a Lena Delta cell in 2013, with the model input accumulated to the observation day and the map input to 1 September (centre); observed ALT against $\sqrt{\mathrm{TDD}_{\mathrm{obs}}}$ for the Alaska site-years with the Stefan anchor and five residuals (right). **b**, Physics-residual model: the Stefan anchor plus gradient boosting of its residual from 23 climate, terrain and soil inputs (equation (5)), illustrated with the Alaska map of 2014. **c**, Validation designs on the Lena Delta label cells (colour marks the fold, the observation year or the test region), and ALT anomalies of the Alaska map in 2012 and 2019.

define the 95% interval,

$$\mathrm{CI}_{95} = \left[ Q_{0.025}\left(\Delta\mathrm{RMSE}^{(b)}\right),\ Q_{0.975}\left(\Delta\mathrm{RMSE}^{(b)}\right) \right], \quad b = 1, \ldots, B. \tag{8}$$

We describe a difference as resolved when its interval excludes zero. Because several sites can lie in one 1 km cell (median 5, 3 and 5 sites per cell in Alaska, the Lena Delta and Canada), the main comparisons were also scored on cell-year means of the observations and predictions (Supplementary Table S7). Conditions of the gain were examined within regional terciles of eight covariates (full-season TDD of the observation year, freezing degree-days, snow water equivalent, soil organic carbon, clay, slope, elevation and summer NDVI); terciles with fewer than 30 site-years or fewer than five blocks were not evaluated. Year-wise RMSE was computed for years with at least 30 site-years, and the correlation between observed and predicted year-to-year changes was computed at cells observed in several years.

## Label-number and transfer experiments

Within each region, the training labels of each spatial-block fold were subsampled to $n$ = 25, 50, 100, 250, 500, 1000, 2500 or all (three random draws), the Stefan coefficient was recalibrated on the same $n$ labels, and the complete test fold was scored. For transfer, each region was scored in its spatial-block folds by models trained on all labels of the other two regions plus $n = 0$, 25, 50, 100, 250 or 500 labels drawn from the training folds of the target region; the Stefan coefficient was refitted on the $n$ target labels, and the residual learner was trained on the source rows anchored with the source coefficient together with the target rows anchored with the refitted coefficient,

$$\widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{\mathrm{T}} = \hat{E}_{\mathrm{T}}\, s + \lambda\, g_{\mathrm{ST}}(\mathbf{x}),$$
$$g_{\mathrm{ST}} = \arg\min_{f} \Big[ \sum_{i \in \mathrm{S}} \big(y_i - \hat{E}_{\mathrm{S}}\, s_i - f(\mathbf{x}_i)\big)^2 + \sum_{i \in \mathrm{T}} \big(y_i - \hat{E}_{\mathrm{T}}\, s_i - f(\mathbf{x}_i)\big)^2 \Big], \tag{9}$$

where S denotes the source rows, T the $n$ target rows, $\hat{E}_{\mathrm{S}}$ the coefficient fitted on the source rows and $\hat{E}_{\mathrm{T}}$ the coefficient refitted on the target rows ($\hat{E}_{\mathrm{T}} = \hat{E}_{\mathrm{S}}$ for $n < 3$); the source rows were not buffered by 100 km in this experiment. The runs are listed in Supplementary Table S4.

## Comparison with published products

Six publicly archived products were downloaded and sampled at the label sites (nearest 1 km pixel; Supplementary Methods S3 and Table S1): the Northern Hemisphere products of Wei et al.[17] (1 km, yearly 2000–2024), Liu et al.[16] (1 km, yearly 2003–2020), ESA CCI Permafrost ALT v4 (1997–2021) and v5 (1997–2023)[14,15] and Aalto et al.[18] (one value per cell for the 2000–2014 baseline), and the Alaska-only product of Yi and Kimball[29] (2001–2015), which was used as a reference and not scored because it covers one region and ends in 2015. For yearly products the value of the observation year was used, so that products and models are compared for the same site and the same year. Products and models were compared on common site-years, at which Wei et al., Liu et al. and ESA CCI v4 all provide a value for the observation year (2010–2020); ESA CCI v5 and Aalto et al. were scored on the common site-years where they have a value, and the year-wise comparison used all site-years of a year with a value of Wei et al. Wei et al. published the coordinates of their training sites, and a leakage mask removed label cells within 25 km of these sites. Liu et al. trained their random forest on CALM and on the ABoVE soil-moisture and active-layer compilation[16], an earlier release of the Alaska and Canada observations used here, so their values at these sites are not independent of our labels; the training sites of Wei et al. overlap with our Alaska sites in the same way. To test whether the residual learner can also correct a product, the product value $p$ of the observation year was recalibrated on the training fold,

$$\hat{p} = a + b\, p, \tag{10}$$

and the residual $y - \hat{p}$ was learned with the same covariates, learner, $\lambda$ and folds as in equation (5) (Supplementary Methods S4).

## Yearly mapping, area of applicability and prediction intervals

For each of the three regions, the recalibrated Stefan and physics-residual models were fitted to all site-years of the region and applied to the 1 km cells with an ESA CCI permafrost probability of at least 50%, that is, the continuous and discontinuous permafrost zones in the classification of Obu et al.[40], where an active layer above permafrost exists and where the labels lie, excluding cells that are water (mean Global Surface Water occurrence of at least 50%) or lack an input (858,517, 38,086 and 1,151,169 cells), using the climate of each year from 2011 to 2024 with the TDD accumulated to 1 September. The area of applicability followed Meyer and Pebesma[41]. With $\mathbf{z}$ the standardised 23-dimensional feature vector (with the 2011–2024 mean of the yearly map inputs), the dissimilarity of map cell $k$ is $d_k = \min_j \|\mathbf{z}_k - \mathbf{z}_j\|_2$ over all training rows $j$, and the cell is inside the area of applicability when

$$d_k \le \tau, \qquad \tau = Q_{0.95}\left\{ \min_{j:\, b(j)\neq b(i)} \|\mathbf{z}_i - \mathbf{z}_j\|_2 \;:\; i \in \text{training rows} \right\}, \tag{11}$$

where $b(\cdot)$ denotes the spatial block. For year $y$ and cell $k$, the anomaly is $a_{k,y} = \widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{k,y} - \overline{\widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_k}$, where the overbar denotes the 2011–2024 mean; the regional mean anomaly is the mean of $a_{k,y}$ over the mapped cells, and the trend of each cell is the least-squares slope

$$\beta_k = \frac{\sum_y (y - \bar{y})\, a_{k,y}}{\sum_y (y - \bar{y})^2}, \tag{12}$$

expressed in cm per decade, as in previous yearly ALT products[16,29]. The observed anomaly of a year is the mean over the labels of that year of $y_i - \overline{\widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{k(i)}}$, where $k(i)$ is the map cell nearest to site $i$ within 1.5 km, computed for years with at least 50 site-years and centred on the mean predicted anomaly of the same years. The 90% prediction interval of a map value is

$$\left[ \widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{k,y} + Q_{0.05}(r),\ \widehat{\mathrm{ALT}}_{k,y} + Q_{0.95}(r) \right], \tag{13}$$

where $r$ denotes the spatial-block out-of-fold residuals of the region. For display, the 1 km values were interpolated bilinearly onto a 250 m (Lena Delta) or 500 m (Alaska, Canada) hillshade grid. For each region, the map of the year with the most observed 1 km cells having a value in our map and in both products (2013 in Alaska and Canada, 2016 in the Lena Delta) was compared with the two ML products on those cells, using the product values of the same year at the label sites, the cell means of the observations and our spatial-block out-of-fold predictions; the product maps are displayed on the cells of our map, and each region uses one colour range from the 5th–95th percentiles of the pooled values of the three maps inside the area of applicability.

## Computation

Models were fitted with fixed random seeds on 96-core CPU nodes, and the neural learners on one NVIDIA A100 GPU; data preparation, aggregation and figures were run on a local server (Supplementary Table S4).

## Code availability

The code for data preparation, modelling, evaluation and figures is available at [repository and DOI]. Every number in the text is generated from the stored result tables by the scripts that produce the manuscript macros.

# Results

## Climate input, validation design and the in-region versus out-of-region contrast

We first ask whether the climate of the observation year matters, how accurate each method is at sites it has not seen, and how much this answer depends on the way the data are split. Replacing the 2011–2024 mean climate input by the input of the observation year reduced the spatial-block RMSE of the recalibrated Stefan model in the Lena Delta (ΔRMSE −1.4 [−2.6, −0.8] cm) and that of the physics-residual model in the Lena Delta (−1.6 [−2.4, −1.0] cm) and Canada (−1.5 [−2.0, −0.4] cm), whereas in Alaska, where half of the labels come from one year, the change was not resolved (Fig. 3a); beyond accuracy, the year-specific input is what ties each prediction to a stated year. Under spatial-block cross-validation with this input, the physics-residual model reduced the RMSE of the recalibrated Stefan model from 21.0 to 17.4 cm in the Lena Delta (ΔRMSE −3.6 [−7.8, −0.8] cm) and from 30.6 to 26.9 cm in Canada (−3.7 [−4.8, −0.8] cm), whereas in Alaska the two models reached 18.6 and 18.4 cm (−0.2 [−0.6, +0.1] cm; Fig. 3b). The scatter of observed against predicted values shows what the learner adds: the recalibrated Stefan model predicts a narrow range of values in every region, because one coefficient applied to the climate of each year cannot separate the sites, whereas the physics-residual model spreads the predictions along the 1:1 line in the Lena Delta and Canada (Supplementary Fig. S11). Direct ML, which learns the whole response from the labels, reached lower point errors than the physics-residual model when all labels of a region were used (Alaska 17.3 versus 18.4, Lena Delta 15.9 versus 17.4 and Canada 26.1 versus 26.9 cm), but its difference from the recalibrated Stefan model was resolved only in Canada (−4.6 [−6.2, −0.2] cm). When the same predictions are scored on 1 km cell-year means instead of site-years, the advantage of direct ML disappears in Alaska (24.7 versus 24.0 cm) and narrows elsewhere (Supplementary Table S7), which indicates that part of it comes from fitting differences between probe points within cells, which a 1 km map cannot use.

The ranking of the methods depended on the validation design (Fig. 3b, Supplementary Table S5). Random cross-validation, which places test sites next to training sites, gave the lowest errors to direct ML (11.8 cm in Alaska); spatial-block cross-validation raised the direct-ML error by 5.4, 3.6 and 9.9 cm in Alaska, the Lena Delta

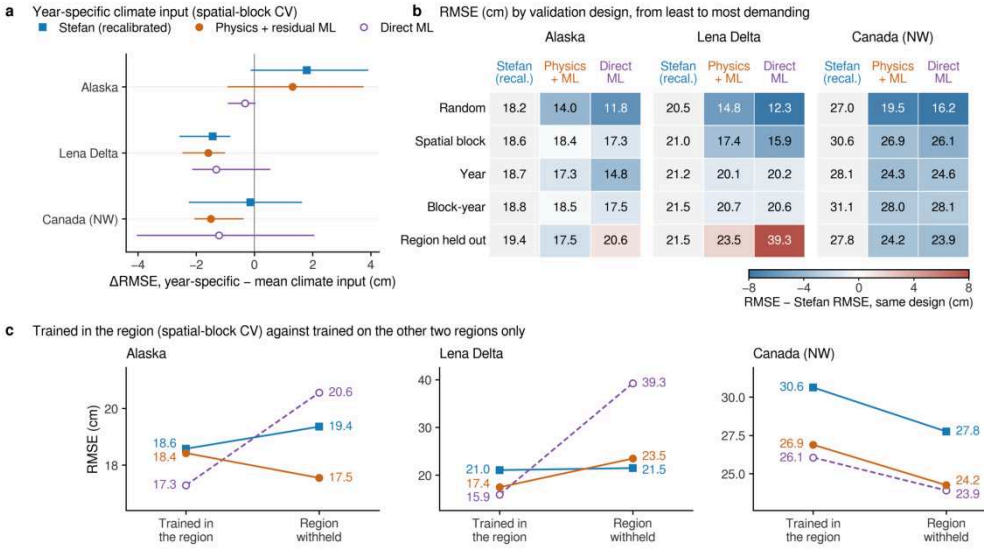



**Fig. 3 Climate input, validation design and the in-region versus out-of-region contrast.** **a**, Change in spatial-block RMSE when the 2011–2024 mean climate input is replaced by the input of the observation year (95% paired block-bootstrap intervals; negative values favour the year-specific input). **b**, RMSE of three methods under five validation designs, ordered from the least to the most demanding; the colour of a cell is its difference from the recalibrated Stefan model of the same design (blue, lower; red, higher), and in the region hold-out the Stefan model uses the coefficient of the other two regions. **c**, RMSE of the same methods when a region's own labels are used (spatial-block cross-validation) and when the region is withheld and the models are trained on the other two regions only.

and Canada, and the year and block-by-year designs raised it further. When an entire region was withheld, the direct-ML error in the Lena Delta rose to 39.3 cm, against 21.5 cm for the Stefan model with the coefficient of the other regions (ΔRMSE +17.8 [+8.0, +23.9] cm), whereas the physics-residual model stayed within 2.0 cm of the Stefan model there and improved on it in Canada (−3.5 [−5.1, −0.1] cm; Fig. 3c). The three methods thus behave differently as test sites move away from training sites: the Stefan model is nearly insensitive to the design because one coefficient cannot overfit, direct ML is the most accurate where test and training sites interleave and the least accurate where they do not, and the physics-residual model keeps most of the in-region gain while inheriting the stability of its anchor. Because maps are needed at cells and in years without observations, spatial-block cross-validation is the main design and the region hold-out the test of transferability.

## Conditions of the physics-residual gain

We next ask what information the learner needs and where the correction acts. The gain depended on the covariates available to the residual learner (Fig. 4a): with climate covariates only, the residual model did not improve on the Stefan model in Alaska (+5.9 [−0.3, +14.2] cm) or Canada (+3.9 [−5.1, +10.3] cm), and adding terrain and soil covariates produced the gains reported above; MODIS vegetation and snow

timing or high-resolution soil and land-cover classes changed the result by less than 0.5 cm in the Lena Delta and Canada, and the latter added a small gain in Alaska (−0.8 [−1.4, −0.2] cm). Across regional terciles of eight covariates, the gain occurred in most conditions of the Lena Delta (19 of 23 terciles with intervals excluding zero) and Canada (17 of 23) and increased with the error of the Stefan model (correlation across terciles −0.99 in the Lena Delta and −0.79 in Canada; Fig. 4b), reaching −6.2 [−12.0, −0.7] cm in the warmest TDD tercile of the Lena Delta. In Alaska no tercile changed by more than 0.9 cm; the absence of a gain is uniform and consistent with two features of the Alaska data: the regional coefficient already represents its sites well (Stefan RMSE 18.6 cm, the lowest of the three regions relative to the range of the observations), and the remaining error is dominated by the spread between probe points within 1 km cells (pooled within-cell standard deviation 13.0 cm), which no 1 km covariate can resolve. Terrain variables accounted for 50% of the mean absolute SHAP value of the residual model in the Lena Delta and soil variables for 39% in Canada (Supplementary Fig. S3). Placing the physics elsewhere, as pseudo-labels (which reproduced the Stefan model, Lena Delta −0.3 [−0.4, −0.1] cm) or as an input feature (which behaved like direct ML), and replacing CatBoost by four other learners did not change the sign of the gain in the Lena Delta and Canada (Supplementary Fig. S2).

## Number of labels within a region and transfer to a new region

The third question is how many local observations the learner needs. With 25 training labels drawn from the site-years of a region, the physics-residual model was at least as accurate as a Stefan model recalibrated on the same labels (Alaska −0.9 [−1.9, +0.1], Lena Delta −0.8 [−2.2, −0.1] and Canada −0.3 [−3.2, +1.7] cm), and with 100 labels its gain was resolved in all three regions (−0.7 [−1.4, 0.0], −2.0 [−5.3, −0.3] and −1.9 [−3.7, −0.3] cm; Supplementary Fig. S4). Direct ML trained on 25 labels had a higher point error than the Stefan model in Alaska (+2.8 [−0.3, +4.5] cm) and Canada (+1.2 [−1.5, +3.4] cm) and overtook the physics-residual model only with several hundred labels in Alaska and the Lena Delta. The two curves do not contradict each other: with thousands of labels direct ML fits them more closely, but the physics-residual model reaches almost the same accuracy with a fraction of the labels and never falls below its anchor. Other model structures: Supplementary Fig. S4.

In the transfer experiment, each region was predicted by models trained on the other two regions and $n$ labels of the target region (Fig. 4c; $n \leq 500$, drawn from the training folds of the target region). Without target labels, direct ML reached 39.5 cm in the Lena Delta, against 21.5 cm for the source-coefficient Stefan model and 23.8 cm for the physics-residual model; 25 target labels reduced the physics-residual error to 19.9 cm and the direct-ML error to 21.3 cm. In Alaska the physics-residual model gave the lowest error at every $n$ (17.8 cm without target labels). In Canada, direct ML trained on the source regions was the most accurate (24.2 cm): recalibrating the Stefan coefficient on 25 Canadian labels increased its error from 27.7 to 31.3 cm, and the physics-residual model, which uses this anchor, followed (24.3 to 26.3 cm). We attribute this to the wide range of thaw depths among the Canadian sites (observed

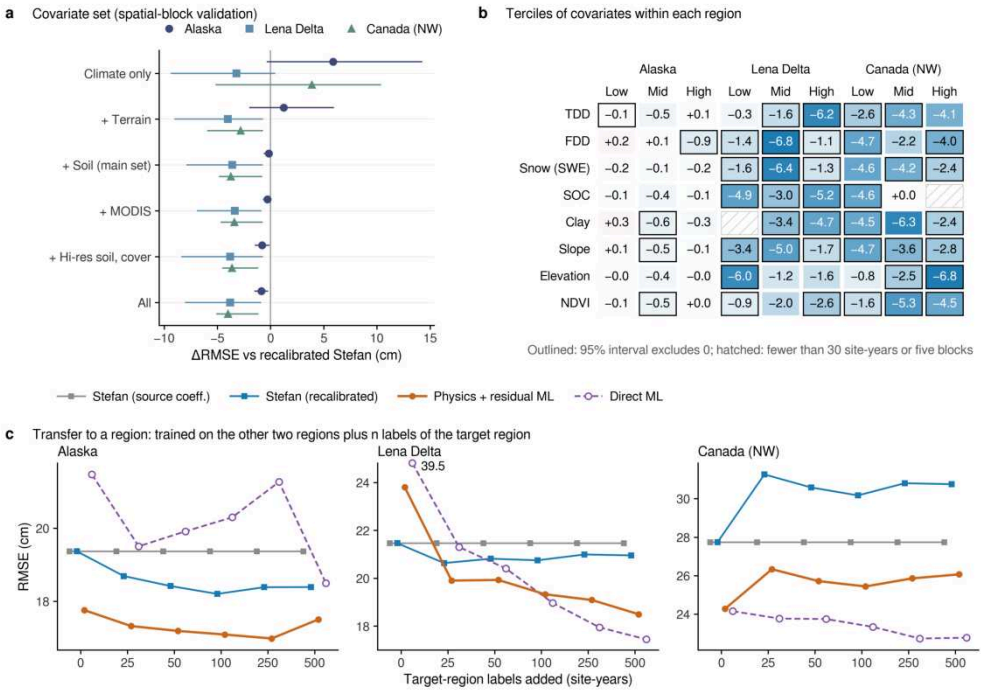



**Fig. 4 Conditions of the physics-residual gain and transfer to a region with few labels.** **a**, Difference in spatial-block RMSE between the physics-residual model and the recalibrated Stefan model for six nested covariate sets. **b**, The same difference within regional terciles of eight covariates; outlined cells have intervals excluding zero, hatched cells fewer than 30 site-years or five blocks. **c**, RMSE in each region for models trained on the other two regions plus $n$ labels of the target region; a value beyond the axis is printed. Intervals in a and b are 95% paired block-bootstrap intervals; negative differences favour the physics-residual model.

means of 63.4 cm at the probe transects and 89.1 cm at the CALM grids), which a coefficient fitted to 25 labels represents poorly.

## Comparison with published products in the same cells and years

We then ask how the published products perform where our labels are, scored in the same way as our models. On the 461 common site-years of the Lena Delta (2010–2020; site-years at which Wei et al., Liu et al. and ESA CCI v4 all provide a value for the observation year), the physics-residual model reached an RMSE of 21.1 cm, against 28.4 cm for ESA CCI v5, 30.6 cm for Aalto et al., 31.0 cm for ESA CCI v4, 33.0 cm for Liu et al. and 34.6 cm for Wei et al. (Fig. 5a, Supplementary Table S6). On the Lena Delta site-years more than 25 km from the training sites of Wei et al. (802 with a value of Wei et al., 2,352 with a value of ESA CCI v5), the paired differences were −12.5 [−15.6, −5.8] cm relative to Wei et al. and −5.0 [−9.5, −2.5] cm relative to ESA CCI v5. In Alaska (17.1 versus 17.9 and 18.8 cm for Wei et al. and Liu et al.)

and Canada (25.8 versus 27.0 and 27.9 cm) the model and the two ML products were on par.

The scatter of observed against predicted values shows why the regions differ (Fig. 5b). In the Lena Delta the two ML products assign most sites values between about 40 and 70 cm regardless of the observed ALT: the correlation between observed and predicted values was 0.05 for Wei et al. and 0.07 for Liu et al., against 0.73 for the physics-residual model, and their mean bias was +21.9 and +19.8 cm, against +2.8 cm, with the largest overestimation at the thin active layers of the northern delta (+21.1 and +19.9 cm north of 72°N). The error distributions (Fig. 5c) separate this systematic bias from the spread: in the Lena Delta the products are shifted by about 20 cm with a spread similar to that of our model, whereas in Alaska and Canada all series are centred near zero and differ mainly in spread. The regional contrast follows the training data of the products. Alaska label sites lie at a median distance of 7 km from the training sites of Wei et al., and Liu et al. trained their model on the ABoVE active-layer compilation, an earlier release of the Alaska and Canada observations used here, so that their values at these sites are not independent of our labels; the Lena Delta sites lie at a median distance of 107 km from the training sites of Wei et al. (Supplementary Fig. S6). A model trained without any Lena Delta label was already more accurate there than Wei et al. on the same site-years (26.0 versus 30.3 cm; $\Delta$RMSE −4.3 [−6.1, −0.8] cm), so that the advantage in this region does not depend on local labels alone. Year by year, the physics-residual model had a lower error than Wei et al. in all 6 Lena Delta years with at least 30 site-years and in 7 of 13 Alaska years (Supplementary Fig. S5).

Maps of the year with the most observed cells in each region (2013 in Alaska and Canada, 2016 in the Lena Delta) show these differences in space (Fig. 6). At the 126 Alaska cells, the RMSE of the three maps was similar (14.9, 13.4 and 12.9 cm). The correlation with the observations was lower for our model (0.34) than for the products (0.53 and 0.57), but 59 of the cells lie within 25 km of a training site of Wei et al.; at the 67 cells beyond that distance the three maps had similar errors (9.1, 10.9 and 8.5 cm; $r$ 0.30, 0.27 and 0.44). The largest differences between the maps occur above 600 m in mountain terrain; between 68 and 70°N the products are deeper than our map there by +18.7 and +52.9 cm. In the Lena Delta (14 cells observed in 2016) both products were deeper than the observations (mean bias +23.6 and +27.3 cm; RMSE 26.2 and 30.4 cm against 12.7 cm). In Canada (NW), the RMSE at the 33 observed cells was 23.7 cm for our model, 29.9 cm for Wei et al. (mean bias +20.5 cm) and 20.2 cm for Liu et al., whose training data include the earlier release of these observations; at the 27 cells beyond 25 km from a training site of Wei et al. the values were 17.5, 31.4 and 21.0 cm.

The residual learner can also be anchored to a product (equation (10)): with the Lena Delta labels the Stefan-anchored model remained more accurate than the product-anchored model (−2.8 [−6.2, −0.1] cm; Supplementary Fig. S7), and in Alaska and Canada the two anchors were not distinguishable.

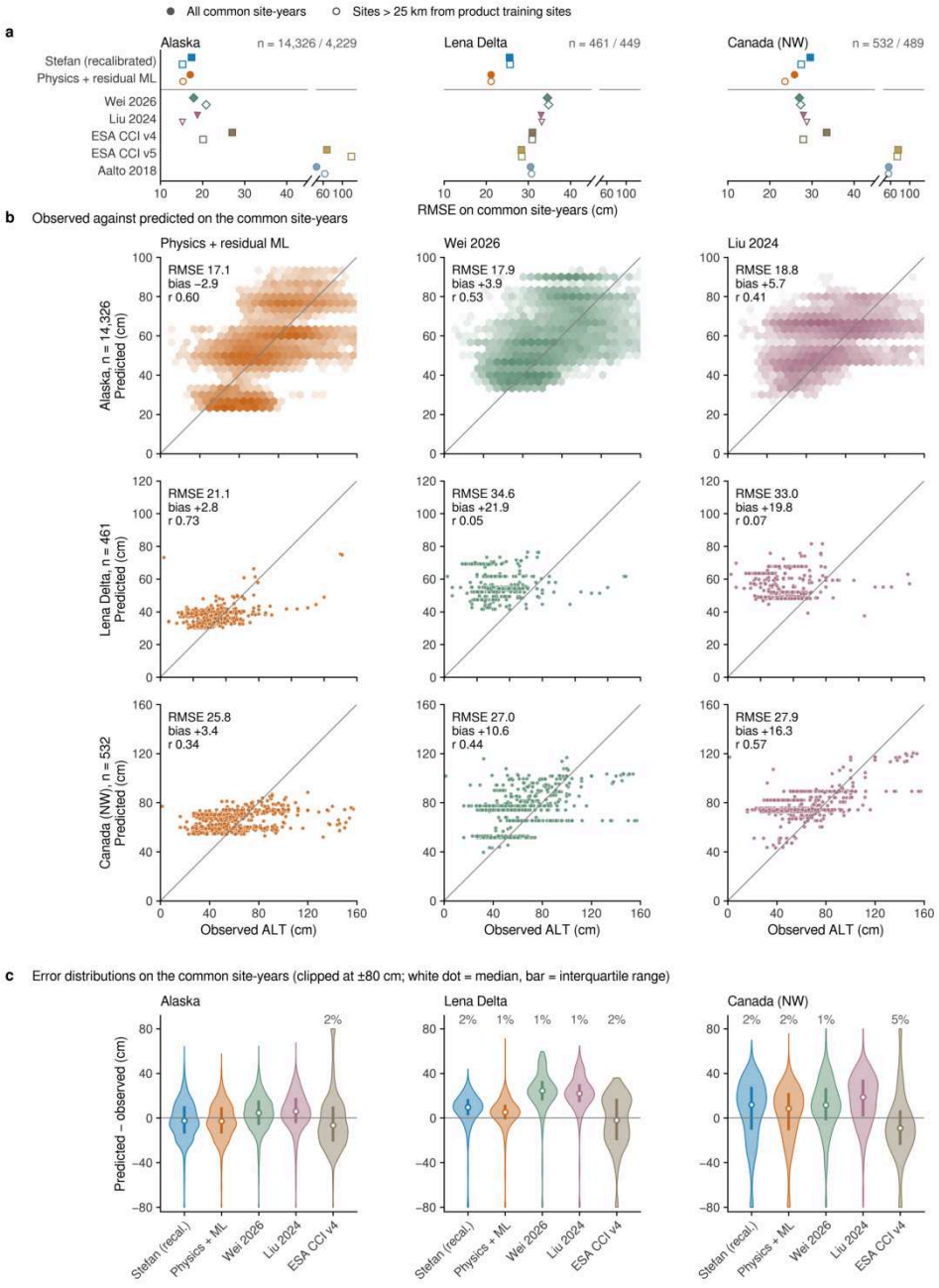



**Fig. 5 Comparison with published products on the same sites and years. a**, RMSE of the recalibrated Stefan model, the physics-residual model and five products on the common site-years (2010–2020), for all sites (filled) and for sites more than 25 km from the training sites of Wei et al. (open); values above 45 cm are drawn on the compressed segment. **b**, Observed against predicted ALT on the common site-years for the physics-residual model, Wei et al. and Liu et al., with the RMSE, mean bias and correlation. **c**, Distribution of predicted minus observed ALT on the same site-years (violins clipped at ±80 cm; dot, median; bar, interquartile range). Our models use spatial-block out-of-fold predictions throughout.

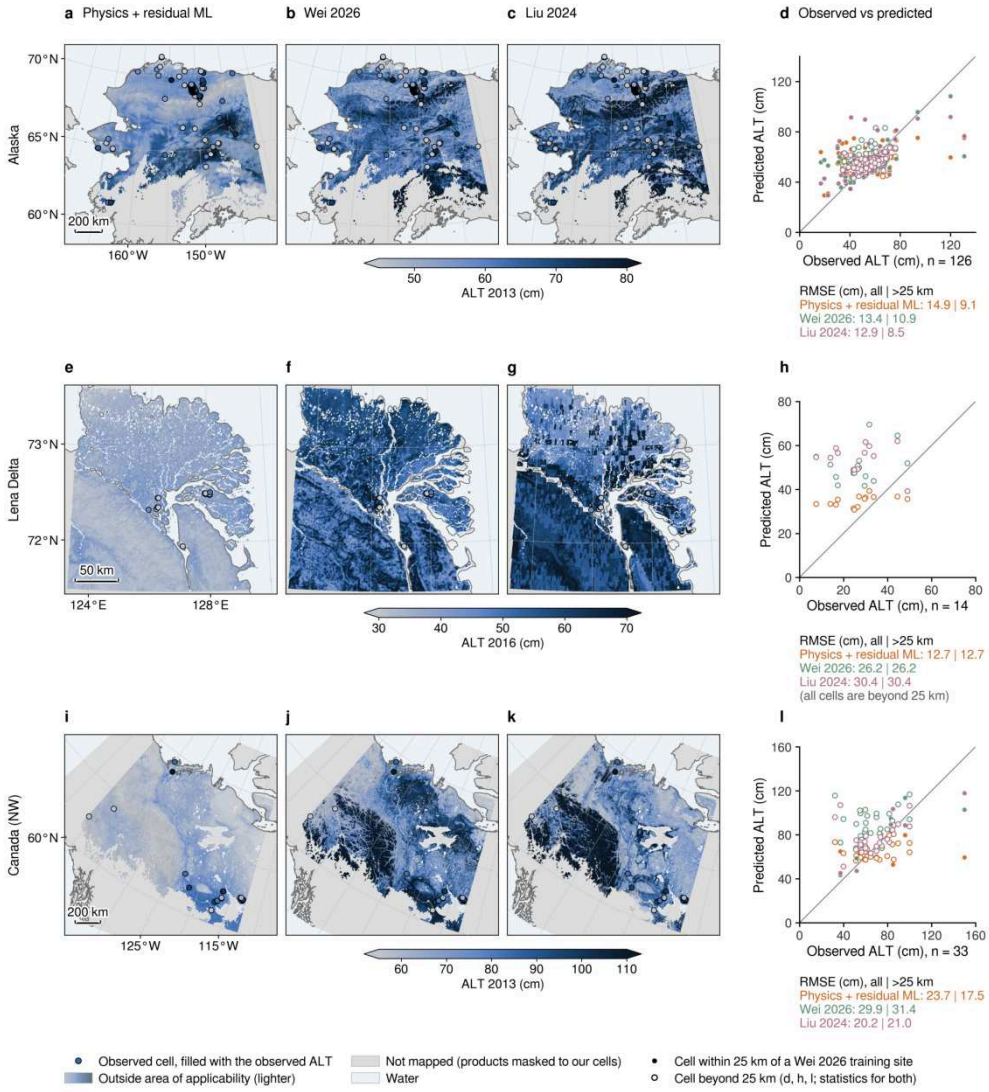



**Fig. 6 ALT maps from the physics-residual model and two published products for the year with the most observed cells in each region, with the observed values. a–c**, Alaska 2013: physics-residual model, Wei et al. and Liu et al.; the product maps are shown on the cells of our map, and the observed cells are drawn as circles filled with the observed ALT on the same colour scale. **d**, Observed against predicted ALT at the 126 observed cells with values in all three maps (1:1 line); filled markers are cells within 25 km of a training site of Wei et al. and open markers cells beyond, and the RMSE is given below the panel for all cells and for the open cells; our predictions are spatial-block out-of-fold values. **e–h**, The same for the Lena Delta 2016 (14 cells). **i–l**, The same for Canada (NW) 2013 (33 cells). Each region has one colour range from the 5th–95th percentiles of the three maps inside the area of applicability; lighter colours mark cells outside it.

## Year-labelled 1 km ALT maps, 2011–2024

Finally, the physics-residual models fitted to all site-years of each region were applied with the ERA5-Land climate of each year from 2011 to 2024 (Fig. 7); the maps cover 858,517 cells in Alaska, 38,086 in the Lena Delta and 1,151,169 in Canada (NW). Relative to the 2011–2024 mean, the regional mean anomaly ranged from −2.8 cm in 2011 to +6.0 cm in 2019 in Alaska, from −8.9 cm in 2016 to +9.0 cm in 2020 in the Lena Delta and from −3.8 cm in 2020 to +6.4 cm in 2023 in Canada (Fig. 7f). These anomalies are the response of the model to the climate of each year: the regional mean anomaly follows the regional mean TDD to 1 September with a correlation of 0.92, 0.96 and 1.00 in Alaska, the Lena Delta and Canada (Fig. 7d), so that the deepest regional thaw falls in the warmest thaw seasons (2019, 2021 and 2023) and the shallowest in the coldest (2014, 2017 and 2020); the residual learner modulates this response spatially, so that the anomaly of a warm year is largest in the interior lowlands of Alaska and smallest on the North Slope (Fig. 7f). A comparison with the yearly means of the observed cells is limited by the changing set of sites measured in each campaign, so Supplementary Fig. S10 compares the mapped and observed series at long-record sites instead. The linear trend of the yearly maps averaged +2.1, +6.7 and +1.5 cm per decade over the Alaska, Lena Delta and Canada cells, with positive values in 78%, 100% and 91% of the cells (Fig. 7e); it describes the ERA5-Land climate of the period as transmitted by the model and is not an observed trend. The area of applicability covers 56% of the Alaska cells, 62% of the Lena Delta cells and 43% of the Canada cells; cells outside it lie mainly in mountains and at the southern margin of the permafrost zone (Supplementary Fig. S8). The half-width of the 90% prediction interval is 25.5, 24.5 and 41.3 cm. Supplementary Fig. S9 shows the residual correction.

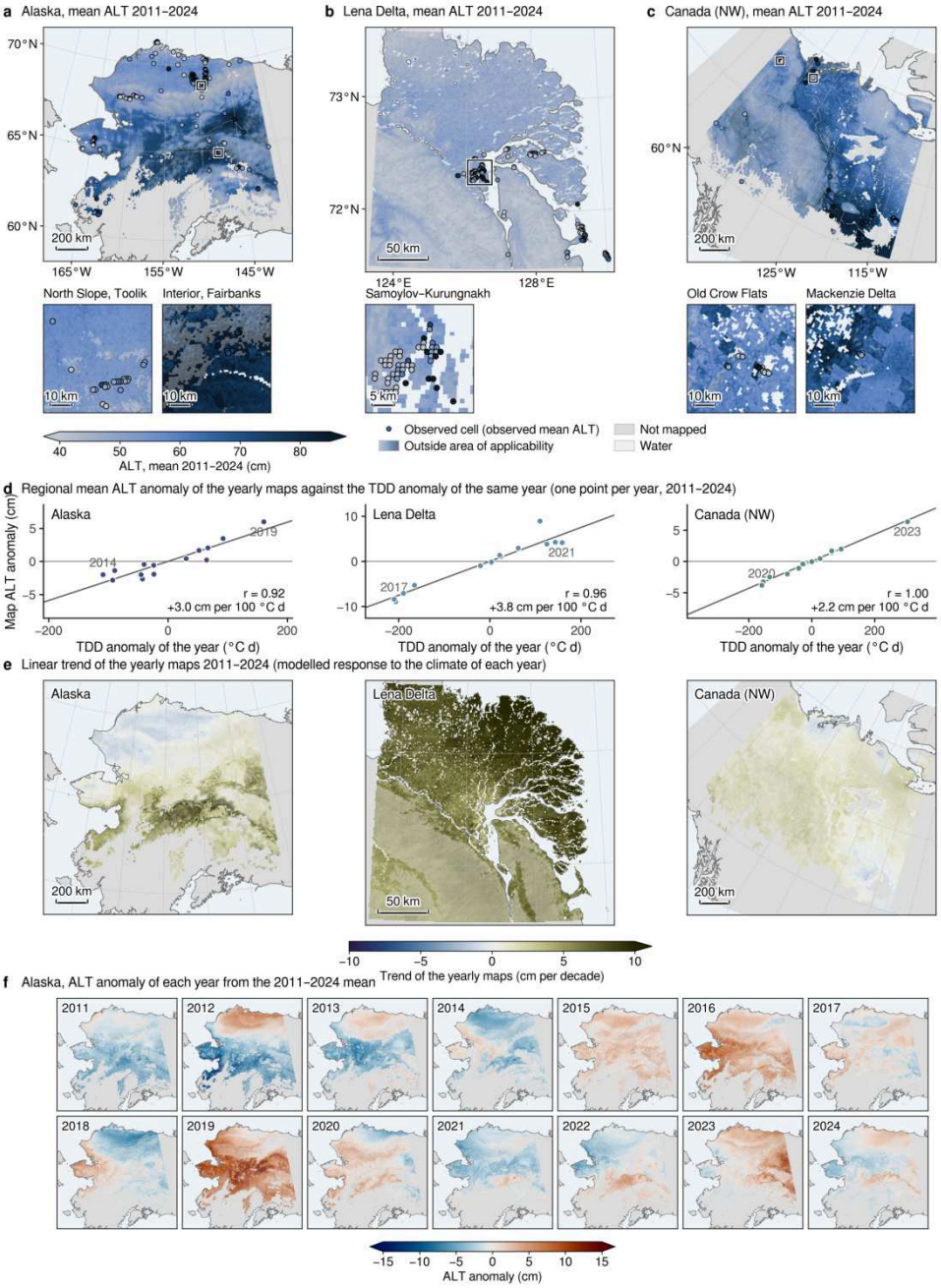



**Fig. 7 Year-labelled 1 km ALT maps, 2011–2024. a–c**, Mean ALT of 2011–2024 from the yearly maps of Alaska, the Lena Delta and Canada (NW), with windows enlarged at the right (1 km cells) and the observed cells filled with their observed mean ALT; lighter colours mark cells outside the area of applicability. **d**, Regional mean ALT anomaly of the yearly maps against the regional mean TDD anomaly of the same year (one point per year, least-squares line; the warmest and coldest thaw seasons are labelled). **e**, Linear trend of the yearly maps (least squares per cell), which describes the modelled response to the climate of each year. **f**, ALT anomaly of each year relative to the 2011–2024 mean in Alaska.

# Discussion

The central result is that where the physical knowledge enters the model decides what the model is good at. In the physics-residual formulation (equation (5)) the Stefan term carries the response to the thaw-season climate of each year in a bounded form, and the learner corrects the departures from one regional coefficient that soils and terrain impose. This division of labour explains the main patterns of the results. The gain over the Stefan model appeared only when terrain and soil covariates were available, because those are the variables that set the effective coefficient; it was largest where the Stefan model erred most, because that is where a correction has something to correct; and the attribution of the residual learner pointed to terrain in the Lena Delta and to soil organic carbon in Canada. Direct ML, which must learn the climate response from the labels, reached lower point errors when thousands of labels of a region were available, but with 25 labels it was less accurate than the Stefan model in Alaska and Canada and, when the Lena Delta was withheld, its error exceeded that of the Stefan model by 17.8 cm. The physics-residual model gave up at most 1.6 cm of the in-region accuracy of direct ML and kept the transferability of its anchor, which matters where labels are scarce.

Alaska is the region in which the correction added nothing, and the reason is informative. With the year-specific input the Stefan term itself absorbs the between-year and between-campaign differences that a learner would otherwise recover from covariates, and the remaining error is the spread between probe points within 1 km cells (pooled standard deviation 13.0 cm), which no 1 km covariate resolves. The uniform absence of a gain across terciles (Fig. 4b) and the same result on cell-year means (Supplementary Table S7) point to this explanation rather than to a shortcoming of the learner. A learner should therefore be added where the regional coefficient misrepresents the sites, which the spatial-block comparison with the recalibrated Stefan model detects, and not by default.

The comparison with the published products on the same sites and years reveals a pattern that their own validations cannot show. Where their training sites are close to our label sites (Alaska, and Canada for Liu et al., whose training data include the earlier release of the same field observations), the ML products were as accurate as our model, and the comparison there is not independent. Where they have no nearby training sites (the Lena Delta, median distance 107 km), they assigned values between about 40 and 70 cm regardless of the observed ALT, overestimated the thin active layers of the northern delta by about 20 cm, and were less accurate than a physics-residual model trained without any Lena Delta label. This is the behaviour of direct ML under region hold-out, reproduced by products whose predictors are yearly but whose climate response is learned from sites elsewhere; the Stefan anchor prevents the same failure because the response to the TDD of the stated year is carried by a term that does not depend on the training sites. The process-based ESA CCI product, which is not trained on ALT observations, was less accurate than our model in all three regions but, unlike the ML products, was not systematically biased in the Lena Delta (Fig. 5c), which is consistent with its physical basis.

These results extend previous comparisons in three directions. Gautam et al.[23] found at 68 Alaska CALM sites of one year that a random forest lost most of its accuracy on held-out sites whereas the Stefan model retained it; we confirm this ordering over site-years of 2010–2024 in three regions and under region hold-out, and show that the two approaches are complementary, because a learner that corrects the Stefan model retains its transferability. Studies of physics-guided learning in lakes and rivers reported that process knowledge helps mainly under data scarcity and extrapolation[20–22]; the label-number and region hold-out experiments give this statement a quantitative form for ALT. The finding that random cross-validation underestimates the spatial-block error of direct ML by 3.6–9.9 cm agrees with the literature on spatial validation[10–12]; errors from random or site-based splits therefore do not indicate the accuracy of a product in a region without training observations.

The yearly maps turn these results into a product with stated conditions of use. Each map is driven by the ERA5-Land climate of one year with the TDD accumulated to 1 September, so that it can be compared with observations or products of the same year, and it carries an area of applicability and a prediction interval. The regional mean anomalies of the maps are the modelled response to the thaw-season climate (correlation with the regional TDD 0.92–1.00); they can be checked against observations only where the same sites are measured year after year, as at the long-record sites of Supplementary Fig. S10, because elsewhere the set of observed cells changes between campaigns, and the linear trends of the maps describe the climate of 2011–2024 as transmitted by the model, not an observed trend. For a region not studied here, the label-number results indicate what to expect rather than a fixed procedure. Without local observations, the Stefan model with a coefficient from other regions, or the physics-residual model trained on other regions, is the safer starting point. Local labels are expected to help once they cover the local range of soils and terrain: 25 Lena Delta labels reduced the error of the physics-residual model from 23.8 to 19.9 cm, whereas 25 Canadian labels increased the error of the recalibrated Stefan model from 27.7 to 31.3 cm, which we attribute to the wide range of thaw depths among the Canadian sites. The spatial-block comparison within the new region and the area of applicability of the resulting map are the checks that distinguish these cases.

The study has limitations that bound these conclusions. Half of the Alaska labels come from 2014, which prevented a resolved estimate of the effect of the year-specific input there, and the Lena Delta labels come from one data set in 16 blocks, which widens the intervals. The labels combine probe transects and CALM grid means from three programmes, and the model error differs between them (Supplementary Table S8), most clearly at the 65 Canadian CALM site-years, whose mean ALT of 89.1 cm is underestimated by −23.0 cm; differences between measurement protocols and site selection are therefore part of the reported errors. The labels are observation sites rather than independent 1 km cells, which the spatial-block design and the cell-year scores account for. The climate input is monthly and the soil covariates are static; the Kudryavtsev model, which includes snow and moisture terms, was more accurate than the recalibrated Stefan model in Canada (25.4 versus 30.6 cm) but less accurate in Alaska (21.7 versus 18.6 cm), and the residual learner recovered most of the Canadian difference, which suggests that a moisture-aware anchor could reduce

it further. Active layers thicker than about 3 m lie outside the training range, and the comparison of maps with observations in one year rests on few cells in the Lena Delta and Canada. Daily climate inputs, remotely sensed snow and soil moisture, and labels from a fourth region are the next steps; because every number here is tied to a stated site, year and validation design, the protocol can be applied to new products and regions as they appear, and the maps extended year by year.

# Conclusions

ALT observations are few and clustered, and the models that extend them to unobserved cells and years face a trade-off between the transferability of a one-coefficient physical model and the accuracy of machine learning at its training sites. This study shows that the trade-off can be avoided by anchoring the learner to the physics. Evaluated on 19,172 site-year observations of three regions with the climate of each observation year, a gradient-boosting model of the residual of a locally recalibrated Stefan model reduced the Stefan error by 3.6 cm in the Lena Delta and 3.7 cm in Canada under spatial-block validation, needed only 25–100 local labels for a resolved gain, and stayed within 2.0 cm of the Stefan model when its region was withheld from training, whereas direct machine learning exceeded the Stefan error by 17.8 cm in that situation. Scored on the same sites and years, the published ML products were as accurate as this model only near their own training sites and did not represent the thin active layers of the Lena Delta, where the physics-residual model was more accurate than all five products. The practical consequences are a year-labelled 1 km ALT map of each region for 2011–2024 with an area of applicability and prediction intervals, an evaluation protocol that makes the accuracy of models and products comparable at stated sites and years, and a rule for new regions: start from the physics, add a learner where local labels show that one coefficient misrepresents the sites, and expect a gain from a few dozen labels rather than from thousands.

**Data availability.** All input data are publicly available. ALT observations: ABoVE soil moisture and active-layer thickness, version 2 (ORNL DAAC, https://doi.org/10.3334/ORNLDAAC/2369), ALLena thaw-depth data (PANGAEA, https://doi.org/10.1594/PANGAEA.973813) and GTN-P CALM (PANGAEA, https://doi.org/10.1594/PANGAEA.972777). Climate: ERA5-Land monthly averaged data (Copernicus Climate Data Store). Covariates: Copernicus DEM GLO-30, SoilGrids 2.0, ESA CCI permafrost probability, and MODIS MOD13Q1 and MOD10A2 version 6.1 (accessed through AppEEARS). Products: Wei et al. (https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21667583), Liu et al. (https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.10070610), ESA CCI ALT v4 and v5 (CEDA), Aalto et al. (https://zenodo.org/records/5003804) and Yi and Kimball (https://doi.org/10.3334/ORNLDAAC/1760). The site-year label table, the yearly climate-input table, the static covariate table, the out-of-fold predictions of all methods and the yearly 1 km maps of Alaska, the Lena Delta and northwestern Canada (2011–2024) will be deposited in a public repository upon acceptance [repository and DOI].

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**Additional information. Supplementary information** accompanies this paper (Supplementary Methods S1–S4, Supplementary Tables S1–S8 and Supplementary Figures S1–S11).

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